How the US Federal AI Use Case Inventory Redraws, Reclassifies, and Overwrites Public-Sector AI

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Public artificial intelligence (AI) inventories promise transparency, but their changing questions and categories complicate accountability over time. We examine the US Federal AI Use Case Inventory across 2023–2025 through record linkage, comparisons accounting for reporting requirements, and qualitative analysis guided by the Algorithmic Decision-Making Adapted for the Public Sector (ADMAPS) framework. Among 272 linked uses previously classified as rights- or safety-impacting, 44 fell outside the subsequent high-impact category. Reclassification explanations were often generic templates or absent. We propose "palimpsestic accountability" to describe how successive releases redraw reporting categories, gate disclosure obligations, and overwrite accounts, leaving readers to reconstruct continuity. We also found that the inventories rarely explained how reviewers exercised judgment in the newly algorithmically mediated workflow. Our findings demonstrate why growing inventories do not necessarily strengthen accountability and motivate the use of stable IDs, documented revisions, explained re-classifications, and accounts of the conditions supporting human oversight.

1 Introduction

Public AI inventories extend the documentation practices that fairness, accountability, and transparency (FAccT) research has advanced for datasets and models [38, 68] to whole portfolios of government AI [71, 79]. In the US, they are a recent instrument of the federal AI transparency regime [64]. A 2020 census found that 64 of the 142 federal agencies it examined had planned, piloted, or implemented AI, documenting 157 use cases [31]. An Executive Order and the Advancing American AI Act subsequently required agencies to inventory their AI use cases [77, 83]. When the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) released the consolidated 2025 inventory, news coverage reported that the number of federal AI uses had more than doubled in a year [3, 54].

While such year-over-year comparisons assume that the inventory counts and describes uses in the same way each year, prior research has mostly examined public AI registers and inventories one release at a time or through aggregate comparisons, documenting what registers disclose or omit [22, 24, 71, 84]. In the US, studies and audits have mostly expressed concerns about unpublished inventories, inaccurate data, and blank fields [7, 8, 60, 103]. However, we know comparatively little about how an instrument's own changes shape what successive entries say, or how the same uses are reclassified and re-described as its questions and categories change. For example, successive OMB memoranda have changed both the inventory's rules (e.g., which uses warrant minimum risk-management practices) and its structure (e.g., replacing the 2024 *rights-impacting* and *safety-impacting* categories with a single *high-impact* category in 2025) [36, 74, 78]. Hence, longitudinal comparison requires following the same use across releases, which the US Federal AI Use Case Inventory makes difficult by changing its questions, categories, and identifiers with each release [64]. In this paper, we examine how the inventory's accounts of the same uses changed from 2023 to 2025, and what those changes made traceable, explainable, and contestable.

Our central insight follows from a simple inference: when the reporting guidelines and structure change, a blank answer, a new classification, or a new assurance of human review can reflect a change in practice, in the question, or only in the record. Therefore, an inventory's accountability cannot be read from any single release and must be reconstructed across releases. We did so in three steps. First, because the inventory lacked persistent identifiers, we re-identified uses within each agency by combining deterministic matches on titles and bureaus with fuzzy matching of titles, descriptions, and bureaus. We manually reviewed every fuzzy-matched candidate above our similarity thresholds and checked chained 2023–2024–2025 links against direct 2023–2025 links. Second, because questions were added, removed, and made conditional, we determined whether

each linked record had to answer each question in each year and counted disclosure gains and losses only where an answer was required in both years. Third, in addition to checking answers' availability, we qualitatively analyzed 171 paired cases and 110 classification justifications through the Algorithmic Decision-Making Adapted for the Public Sector (ADMAPS) framework [91].

Our results show that of 272 linked uses classified as rights- or safety-impacting in 2024, 44 fell outside the 2025 *high-impact* category; among the 30 deployed in both years, 17 cited one repeated template sentence for explanation, and 12 gave none. Every governance answer lost between years came from the same nine systems in one department. Entries became more specific about data, limitations, and who could correct an output, but rarely explained how human personnel weighed that output against other evidence. We propose the concept of *"palimpsestic accountability"* to describe how routine reporting changes shift the work of sensemaking of accountability artifacts from agencies to the public. In the sections to follow, we review prior work, describe our methods, present our results, and discuss implications for more traceable inventories.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Algorithmic Accountability as Institutional Practice in the Public Sector

Over the past decade, governments, companies, and international organizations have published hundreds of guidelines committing AI development and use to principles like fairness, accountability, and transparency [19, 47]. Accountability is commonly understood as a relationship in which an actor must explain and justify its conduct [11]. Algorithmic accountability research contextualizes this view to ask how responsibility for automated decisions can be traced, justified, and assigned [9, 16, 27, 108], and how transparency, understood as the disclosure of system properties [34], supports that relationship. However, making a system visible does not by itself make it understandable [6], and more information does not necessarily increase trust [55]. Disclosures are situated communications whose content, format, and intention shape what audiences can know [33, 72].

Sociotechnical scholarship demonstrates how accountability is further complicatedly located in the organizations that use algorithmic systems. Selbst et al. [96] show how abstracting a model from its social setting produces "traps" that technical fixes cannot resolve, and public-sector practitioners have described fairness and transparency needs that technical tools rarely anticipate [104]. Accountability is therefore an ongoing institutional accomplishment distributed across algorithmic supply chains that connect agencies, vendors, and developers [18], and not a property of code alone [37, 48]. Hence, AI can enter public organizations through informal channels that receive little scrutiny [44]. For example, vendors often treat the documentation they supply as marketing, whereas agencies need it for vetting [57]. As algorithmic systems are now increasingly being used to decide social welfare eligibility (e.g., [32, 58, 89, 90]), affected communities have raised concerns about their fairness, opacity, and contestability [14, 88]. Overall, responsible administrative practices and trustworthy-AI practices are becoming symbiotically intertwined [43, 70].

Public-sector algorithms also reconfigure discretion: as these systems spread, discretion shifts from street-level officials to the designers of "system-level" bureaucracies [12], a shift that later research describes as digital discretion [4, 15]. Empirical studies of child welfare [53, 92], homelessness services [69], policing [97], and higher education [65] show that algorithmic decision support redistributes rather than removes discretion, which remains shaped by workers' contextual knowledge, organizational pressures, and power relations within agencies [52]. Consequently, requirements that a human remain "in the loop" are not self-explanatory safeguards. Human reviewers may be unable to perform the oversight that policies assume [40], may be reduced to rubber-stamping otherwise automated decisions [105], and may follow algorithmic advice selectively when it aligns with stereotypes [5]. Effective oversight depends on reviewers' causal power,

epistemic access, and institutional support [100, 101], while law often shapes these human roles without acknowledging it [20]. Human judgment remains valuable partly because it can attend to the particulars of individual cases [10]. Hence, claims of human involvement in public-sector AI call for examining the organizational conditions under which that involvement occurs.

2.2 Algorithmic Accountability Artifacts as Classification Infrastructures

Documentation artifacts are one of the main ways accountability relationships are made concrete. Datasheets [38], model cards [68], internal audits [87], and impact assessments [107] standardize information about provenance, intended use, limitations, and responsible actors so that it can circulate among developers, organizations, regulators, and publics. However, producing an accountability artifact and achieving accountability are different accomplishments. Weak incentives, scarce resources, and poor integration with organizational workflows often constrain their expected governance benefits [111], as evidenced by the fact that sections on limitations and evaluation are among the least often completed [62]. Impact assessments face related limits. The "impacts" they record are evaluative constructs that risk becoming organizationally legible metrics distant from the harms people experience [23, 67], and assessment regimes depend on the good-faith participation of the organizations that control information about their own systems [95].

Moreover, documentation does not neutrally describe the systems it accompanies. While claims of scale, completeness, or neutrality can obscure the infrastructure—the sociotechnical arrangements of humans, organizations, and technologies [61] and the questions like how data are produced and whose labor they depend on [26, 93], reading datasets and disclosure datasets critically reveals the classificatory and political choices encoded in them [85, 86]. Scholars have argued that classification and categories make heterogeneous things comparable while determining which distinctions become consequential and whose experiences are left out [13]. In AI governance, risk-based regulation ties obligations to such categories, which can frame policy choices as technical and make harms that are hard to quantify less visible [49]. Analyses of the European Union (EU)'s AI Act show how its high-risk category is specified through combinations of core concepts [39]. In the US context, Friedler and Selbst argue that consolidating "rights-impacting" and "safety-impacting" AI into "high-impact" AI preserved much of the earlier OMB memo's structure [36], which leaves open how agencies applied the new category to particular uses.

Infrastructures and their classifications also change over time [13]. Social computing research distinguishes the short horizons of projects from the long "infrastructure time" of stewardship [50], treats maintenance and repair as central to technology [45], and describes metadata as an ongoing communicative process [30]. Recent work brings this temporal concern to AI documentation. Luccioni et al. show that deprecated datasets often continue to circulate without standardized identification and communication [63], and deployed models can change without corresponding documentation updates [2]. Structured transparency databases, such as the EU's Digital Services Act Transparency Database, standardize reporting while allowing reporting organizations' discretion over what they disclose [51]. That led to inconsistencies in the database across reporting periods [41, 98], and harmonized templates for platforms' transparency reports have not reconciled those reports with the database [102]. Similarly, the discretion built into New York City's bias-audit law produced what Wright et al. call "null compliance", in which employers could avoid compliance without appearing non-compliant [113]. However, studies of public AI registers have rarely examined how their records, and the categories that structure them, change across reporting cycles.

2.3 Public AI Registers and Inventories across the World

Public AI registers and inventories carry this documentation logic from single datasets or models to an institution's entire portfolio of algorithmic systems. Amsterdam and Helsinki launched some

of the first municipal registers in 2020 [35, 42], and similar initiatives have emerged in French cities [80], Chile [59], the UK [84, 114], Canada [73], and other municipal and national governments [99]. By 2024, a report for the Global Partnership on AI identified 69 active public algorithm repositories worldwide [79]. While registers are presented as a way to establish AI as a transparent and trustworthy public service [35], scholars have warned that they could decontextualize and depoliticize systems whose harms in the digital welfare state were already documented [17]. Drawing on interviews and policy documents, Nieuwenhuizen found that Dutch organizations disclosed selectively and that registers were of limited use to oversight bodies and watchdogs [71], while case studies of Dutch public organizations revealed immature and highly variable practices for managing registers [94]. Peljto et al. similarly found that two German platforms published no update obligations and did not version their entries [82]. Participatory mapping of a Dutch register entry likewise surfaced hazards, such as wrongful benefit denials and limited contestability, that the entry itself did not reveal [25]. Comparing Chinese and British registers, Pi et al. show that registers can serve functions ranging from public disclosure to pre-market approval and regulatory coordination, depending on their design [84]. Across 72 countries, registers share a descriptive core but rarely request information about appeals, risks, or external evaluation [22].

Research on the US federal AI Use Case Inventory has focused mainly on implementation and completeness, finding that roughly half or more of federal agencies had not published the required inventories [60] and that 15 of the 20 inventories the Government Accountability Office reviewed contained incomplete or inaccurate data [103]. Nearly half of agencies' compliance plans for OMB's 2024 memorandum did not explain how their inventories would be comprehensive [106], and civil society reviews have documented inconsistent and blank risk designations [7, 8]. Others have used the inventory to gauge federal adoption itself, finding disclosed uses concentrated in large agencies [112]. Most closely related to our work, Lurie et al. linked disclosures across the AI Use Case Inventory and two other federal disclosure regimes and matched 2024 entries to 2025 entries [64]. They highlighted that the absence of persistent identifiers, uneven granularity, and the annual reporting cycle make it difficult to track systems across regimes and over time. Due to these challenges, we know comparatively little about how the same uses are reclassified and rephrased as an inventory's questions and categories change. Moreover, a sociotechnical reading can make such shifts interpretable by treating each entry not as a neutral description of a system but as an agency's account of how that system is arranged with people, rules, and organizational routines, so that a changed description can be traced to changes in the reporting rules, the organization, or the system itself. Hence, we build on these studies in three ways. First, we link uses across all three US releases. Second, we read each missing answer against whether that year's rules required it and follow uses from the earlier rights- and safety-impacting categories into the later high-impact categories, addressing Friedler and Selbst's open question of whether the latest inventory release followed updated or earlier reporting instructions and structures [36]. Third, we interpret agencies' changing accounts of algorithmic roles and human judgment through a sociotechnical lens.

To examine these accounts, we draw on the ADMAPS framework [91], synthesized from public administration, STS, and HCI scholarship. Instead of treating algorithms used in the public sector as stand-alone technical artifacts, it examines the intersection of three dimensions: *bureaucratic processes* comprising resources and constraints, administration and training, and laws and policies; *algorithmic decision-making* comprising relevant data, types of decision support, and the degree of uncertainty; and *Human discretion* comprising professional expertise, value judgments, and heuristic decision-making. Das and colleagues have applied it to examine Canada's federal AI Register and showed how a public inventory of AI use cases can foreground technical capabilities and efficiency while leaving human discretion, training, and uncertainty management largely unaccounted for [24]. Following this work, we use ADMAPS to read the US inventory's successive

accounts of AI, attending to how changes in reporting rules, descriptions of algorithmic roles, and representations of human judgment together shape what the public can examine over time.

3 Methods

We conducted a longitudinal mixed-methods study of the US Federal AI Use Case Inventory across three reporting cycles (2023–2025). We examined how agencies described AI uses over time and how changes in reporting requirements shaped the information available in these descriptions. To do so, we compared the annual reporting materials, linked use-case entries across years, and combined descriptive quantitative analysis and qualitative analysis guided by the ADMAPS framework [91], which allowed us to examine descriptions of algorithmic functions alongside the organizational conditions and human judgments involved in their use. In the following sections, we describe our data sources, reconstruction of comparable fields and records, quantitative analyses, and qualitative interpretation.

3.1 Data Sources and Research Scope

We used the official inventories maintained by OMB. The 2023 and 2024 consolidated files came from OMB's 2024 inventory repository[1], and the 2025 files came from its 2025 repository.[2] The individual-use-case files contained 710 records and 10 fields in 2023, 2,133 records and 62 fields in 2024, and 3,611 records and 36 fields in 2025. The 2025 release also included a separate commercial-off-the-shelf (COTS) inventory containing 900 agency–task-category rows. We included this file in our comparison of reporting arrangements but excluded it from record linkage because it summarizes categories and does not report individually identifiable use cases. We also examined the annual submission instructions, data dictionaries, released schemas, and policy documents referenced in those materials. Reading them together allowed us to distinguish what agencies were asked to submit from what appeared in the consolidated public files. As Das et al. [24] highlighted in the Canadian context, the sizes of such inventories describe public reporting coverage and are not a directly comparable measure of AI adoption.

3.2 Reconstructing Reporting Requirements and Comparable Information

We constructed a field-level crosswalk identifying questions introduced, removed, renamed, split, consolidated, or moved to another reporting channel across years. We compared recurring concepts while documenting differences in wording and scope. For example, the 2024 contract-identifier question and the 2025 vendor-name question both concern procurement traceability, but request different information. Similarly, the 2025 request for describing data goes beyond the 2024 request about which data agencies owned. We retained these distinctions when interpreting response availability. For each record and question, we determined whether that year's reporting rules required a response, based on memos, documentation, and the data dictionaries. We evaluated conditional requirements using each record's answers to the relevant questions (e.g., reported lifecycle stage and impact classification). A missing answer has different implications when a question remains required than when it becomes optional or is removed. Where missing or unrecognized answers prevented a determination, eligibility remained unknown. The audit distinguishes *required*, *not required*, *optional*, *unknown*, and *undocumented* requirements[3]. Although submission guidance existed in 2023, the repository did not provide a field-level dictionary for its ten-column consolidated

[1] https://github.com/ombegov/2024-Federal-AI-Use-Case-Inventory/

[2] https://github.com/ombegov/2025-Federal-Agency-AI-Use-Case-Inventory/

[3] A question was *optional* when the dictionary did not require it for any record, and *not required* when it was conditionally required but the record's own answers, such as its lifecycle stage or impact classification, placed it outside that condition.

public file. We did not infer released-field requirements from the broader submission template, and restricted record-level requirement comparisons only to 2024–2025.

Separately, we classified responses as *Present*, *No*, *Blank*, *Unknown*, *Not applicable*, *Withheld*, or *Invalid*. *Blank* includes empty or whitespace-only cells and the configured missing-value placeholders `[]`, `{}`, `null`, and `nan`. We identified the other states through configured text-matching rules. *Invalid* identifies documented wrong-question responses, such as monitoring-related answers presented in an operator-training field. We used a GPT-based agent to flag such instances. *Present* is the residual category for non-blank responses not assigned another state; it does not establish their completeness, relevance, or accuracy. Original responses were retained for interpretation, and the classification rules are described in Appendix A.1. We distinguished "not applicable" from blanks to avoid exempting those from the reporting requirement.

We retained the original lifecycle and impact labels alongside the harmonized categories. We treated the 2024 rights- and safety-impacting categories and the 2025 high-impact categories as classifications under different reporting regimes, rather than interchangeable risk measures.

3.3 Reconstructing Longitudinally Linked Use-Case Sets

We constructed separate 2023–2024, 2024–2025, and direct 2023–2025 linked sets of use cases. Because the 2024 public file did not have identifiers and use-case names could change, we could not follow records using a stable identifier alone. We standardized agency-name variants and restricted comparisons to records within the same agency. We then combined deterministic matching with author review of similarity-based candidates.

Deterministic matching proceeded through unique normalized identifiers, unique normalized titles, repeated titles disambiguated by bureau evidence, and unique title-prefix matches. Each step used only records that remained unmatched after the previous steps. For the remaining records, we combined title, description, and bureau similarity and used maximum-weight Hungarian assignment to generate one-to-one candidate pairs within agencies, following prior works for string matching (e.g., [21, 46]). We reviewed the candidates above a set of threshold values. Appendix A.1 describes the normalization rules, similarity weights, thresholds, and counts by matching method.

The first author reviewed all 273 candidates meeting the thresholds, considering titles, bureaus, narratives, scores, and margins relative to competing matches. The review sheets also displayed provisional labels and notes, so the review was not blinded. Decisions distinguished accepted, rejected, and uncertain pairs. We included the accepted candidates in the deterministic matches. This produced 254 links for 2023–2024, 1,332 for 2024–2025, and 227 for the direct 2023–2025 linked sets. Records without an accepted link remained unlinked, rather than being treated as newly introduced or discontinued systems.

3.4 Quantitative Longitudinal Analysis

We first compared the reporting instruments and linked records, then examined whether answers remained available under continuing requirements. This distinction let us separate changes in the questions agencies received from changes in their responses.

3.4.1 Reporting Coverage, Traceability, and Classification. We characterized inventories and public schemas across years. Within each linked set (e.g., 2023–2024, 2024–2025), we calculated linkage coverage relative to both years' inventories. We also examined changes in titles, agency labels, bureaus, and identifiers. We compared normalized attribute values and reported unavailable values separately. We also joined adjacent-year links through their shared 2024 record and compared their endpoints with the direct 2023–2025 linked set. This identified corroborated chains, chains without

a direct link, and conflicting destinations, which remained unresolved. Because the paths used overlapping evidence and procedures, this comparison assessed internal consistency.

We constructed lifecycle-transition matrices for all three linked sets. We also constructed an impact-classification transition matrix and examined its relationship to reported lifecycle within the 2024–2025 linked set, since the 2023 release did not disclose comparable impact classifications.

3.4.2 Requirement Transitions and Response Availability. We examined 12 cross-year concepts covering procurement and vendor or contract traceability, personally identifiable information and data descriptions, custom code and source-code availability, authorization-to-operate status and associated system names, impact assessment, independent review, monitoring, and appeal or contestation. For each linked record–field pair, we identified whether a response was required in both years, changed from required to not required, changed from not required to required, or was not required in either year. Other combinations were unclassifiable for this binary comparison; their underlying optional, unknown, or undocumented states remained distinct in the audit.

Only observations required in both years entered the denominator for disclosure transitions. Within this population, Present and No responses counted as disclosed, while Blank responses counted as missing. A blank becoming disclosed was a gain, and a disclosed answer becoming blank was a loss. We also recorded answers that remained disclosed or blank. Transitions involving Unknown, Not applicable, Withheld, or Invalid remained in the denominator but were reported separately from these four combinations. Thus, each concept had its own denominator. The source-code-link field, which became optional in 2025, had no required-in-both observations.

This measure captures response availability for each question, not the quality of an answer or the effectiveness of a safeguard. For example, an in-progress status and an established control both count as disclosed, without telling us many details. Therefore, we also examined the reported values. To contextualize the linked comparisons, we examined governance responses across all 227 records reported as deployed and high-impact in 2025, including unlinked records. We examined agency concentration and also analyzed newly introduced fields (e.g., operator training) separately.

3.5 ADMAPS-Guided Qualitative Analysis

3.5.1 Preparing Longitudinal Cases and Classification Justifications. We selected linked cases reported as deployed in both 2024 and 2025, classified as rights-impacting, safety-impacting, or both in 2024, and assigned an explicit high-impact or not-high-impact classification in 2025. This produced 171 paired cases: 141 classified as “high-impact" in 2025, 17 as “not-high-impact", and 13 as “presumed high-impact but determined not to be high-impact". Restricting the cohort to reported deployment in both years allowed us to examine changes in classification and description without also varying reported lifecycle status. We assembled each year’s purposes, benefits, outputs, classifications, and relevant data, governance, and human-involvement fields side by side.

We contextualized these trajectories with all 110 records in the 2025 “Presumed High-Impact, but Not High-Impact" category, irrespective of lifecycle stage or linkage. Their justification fields contained 109 non-blank explanations and one blank. For the textual-reuse analysis, we applied Unicode NFKC normalization[4], standardized typographic quotation marks and dashes, and collapsed whitespace while preserving wording and case. This yielded 69 distinct explanation texts, each linked to its originating records and agencies. Since 13 records overlapped with the paired cohort, the two corpora contained $171 + 110 - 13 = 268$ distinct 2025 records in total.

[4]It converts visually distinct variations of characters (e.g., full-width characters, ligatures, Roman numerals, or superscript numbers) into their standard, plain-text equivalents [1].

3.5.2 Interpreting Organizational Conditions, Algorithmic Roles, and Human Judgment. We used each individual AI use-case entry as the unit of coding and each linked pair as the unit of longitudinal comparison. The first author conducted the initial coding, attending to representations of actors, tasks, objectives, inputs, outputs, limitations, human intervention, and governance arrangements. The codes were refined through discussions with the other three authors. We read related fields together when comparing linked entries. For example, we compared the combined 2024 purpose-and-benefits field with both the problem and benefits fields in 2025. This allowed us to distinguish changes in the account from information that moved between questions. We considered repeated justifications with their record-level contexts, preserving the distinction between shared language and the different uses it described. We documented disagreements and ambiguities in analytic memos, resolved them collaboratively, and merged, split, or adjusted codes to maintain consistency. Consistent with such collaborative interpretive approach and methodological guidance in social computing research [66], we did not calculate an inter-coder reliability score.

To examine how agencies framed AI uses, we mapped the codes to the three dimensions of the ADMAPS framework [91]. The dimensions were not mutually exclusive. For example, several entries describe an operator verifying an automated cell classification and being able to change it. This account connects an algorithmic output with human authority to intervene, but does not itself explain the operator's qualifications or reasoning. Such distinctions allowed us to interpret relationships across dimensions without treating every mention of human review as evidence of expertise or a decision-making heuristic.

3.6 Connecting Quantitative Patterns and Qualitative Accounts

We interpreted narrative comparisons alongside quantitative patterns in reporting requirements, response availability, and classification. Whereas the quantitative measure identifies whether a response remains available, the qualitative analysis examines what that response says. For example, a populated field can become less specific, or a broader question can elicit additional detail. We examined these differences by comparing similar agencies or functional settings, without treating the cases as causally matched groups. We compared textual fields by source years in the paired cohort. We used them to explain patterns and contrasts.

4 Results

The public account of federal AI use changed through revisions to reporting requirements, descriptions of algorithmic functions, and representations of human judgment. These changes did not uniformly increase or decrease disclosure. Some entries provided more specific accounts of data, limitations, and intervention, while other information disappeared from responses or from the reporting instrument itself. We organize these findings through the three ADMAPS dimensions: *bureaucratic processes*, *algorithmic decision-making*, and *human discretion*.

The comparisons draw on 254 accepted links between 2023 and 2024, 1,332 between 2024 and 2025, and 227 direct links between 2023 and 2025. The detailed requirements and narrative comparisons are based on 2024–2025, when richer information was available. Within that set, the qualitative cohort comprises 171 cases reported as deployed in both years and as rights- or safety-impacting in 2024. In 2025, 141 were classified as high-impact, and 30 fell into the two not-high-impact categories. Throughout the findings, we distinguish changes in these public accounts from independently established changes in deployment, risk, or workers' practices.

4.1 Bureaucratic Processes

Changes in the inventories' questions, classifications, and administrative requirements shaped what the public could inspect. Growth in the number of records did not produce a correspondingly continuous account of organizational support or governance.

4.1.1 Laws and Policies: Changing the Conditions of Disclosure. The number of individually reported use cases increased from 710 in 2023 to 2,133 in 2024 and 3,611 in 2025, while the public files expanded from 10 to 62 fields and then contracted to 36. These changes affected both the composition and size of reporting. The 2025 release separated the problem being addressed from the expected benefits, introduced a conditional explanation for uses presumed high-impact but determined not to be high-impact, and included operator-training and fail-safe status fields. At the same time, the individual-use-case file no longer included dedicated questions about infrastructure support, direct human involvement, notice, disparity mitigation, and a human-alternative opt-out. A separate COTS channel contained 900 agency–task-category rows rather than 900 individually traceable systems. Thus, the annual totals reflect changing reporting coverage, not a directly comparable measure of AI adoption, and the field counts alone do not capture disclosure quality.

Public traceability also changed across releases. The 2023 consolidated file included use-case identifiers, the 2024 file omitted them, and the 2025 file restored an identifier field but left it blank for 704 records. Even among the 166 direct 2023–2025 pairs with identifiers observed at both endpoints, none retained the same normalized identifier. Within the 2024–2025 linked set, normalized titles changed for 180 of 1,332 pairs (13.5%), and bureau labels changed for 577 of the 1,314 pairs with bureau information in both years (43.9%). These changes reflect identifying information, not organizational transfers. Following a use case therefore required reconstructing continuity across labels rather than simply looking up a stable public identifier.

[Some of the descriptive stats in the two paragraphs above were also mentioned in the methods. Trying to decide which is a better placement without repeating.]

Impact classifications likewise changed between reporting regimes. Of the 272 linked records classified as rights-impacting, safety-impacting, or both in 2024, 228 were "high-impact" in 2025 (83.8%), 16 were "presumed high-impact but determined not high-impact" (5.9%), and 28 were "not-high-impact" (10.3%). In contrast, 13 of the 1,045 records classified as neither rights- nor safety-impacting in 2024 became "high-impact" in 2025. Changes in reported deployment alone did not explain the pattern: among the 171 cases reported as deployed in both years, 141 were "high-impact" in 2025 (82.5%), 13 were "presumed but determined not high-impact", and 17 were "not-high-impact". These transitions create different institutional classifications of linked use cases without corresponding changes in their underlying consequences.

We focused on the distinction between "presumed-but-determined-not" and general "not-high-impact" categories to closely inspect the reasons for classification. All 13 deployed cases in the former cohort supplied a justification, compared with five of the 17 ordinary not-high-impact cases. The remaining 12 lacked an explanation in a category where that field was not required. Among the 30 cases outside high impact, 17 used the same DOJ sentence about an output not serving as a principal basis for consequential decisions. The same formulation appeared in 32 of the 109 non-blank justifications in the broader "presumed-but-determined-not" corpus (29.4%). Across that broader corpus, 109 responses contained 69 distinct normalized texts. **[Also mentioned in the methods–I don't want to repeat –so where to keep it?]**

LexisNexis Accurint (DOJ-0019) illustrates the relationship between a continuing functional account and a new classification explanation. Both years described a system that *"strategically directs focus toward high-value leads"*; its output description also remained unchanged. Nevertheless,

its classification moved from rights-impacting to presumed high-impact but determined not high-impact. The 2025 justification stated that the system *"Does not produce an output that serves as a principal basis for decisions or actions with legal, material, binding, or significant effect"*. The explanation identifies the asserted boundary around consequential influence, but does not specify how the influence of a particular lead or recommendation was assessed. Reuse of this wording makes a shared classificatory rationale visible; it does not show whether agencies internally performed the same assessment, different assessments, or no assessment.

4.1.2 Resources and Constraints: Continuing Resource Claims amid Changing Questions. Organizational resources became visible through different parts of the inventory over time. The 2024 inventory included dedicated questions about developer tools, infrastructure provisioning, access to computing resources, reuse, and internal review. Those dedicated questions were removed in 2025. Consequently, a continuing use case could remain in the inventory without a corresponding opportunity to update these particular accounts of institutional support. The agencies may still be providing those resources, but the inventory does not mention it.

Other resource-related information became more available. Among the 548 linked cases for which a procurement or development-method response was required in both years, 116 gained an answer (21.2%), and five became blank (0.9%); 425 remained answered, and two remained blank (Table 1). However, the response choices and the COTS reporting boundary changed. Similarly, replacing a procurement-instrument identifier with a vendor name made supplier identity available through a different question. However, these answers do not establish what staff, tools, or computing capacity human officers could actually access.

The paired narratives (e.g., purpose and benefits) connected AI use to organizational demands. In 2024, DHS's Hurricane Score (DHS-2408) was framed as a way to produce *"time savings and eliminate human error due to overburdened officers"*. Its 2025 benefits account emphasized processing substantial case information and stated that the system *"helps officers allocate case management resources more effectively while maintaining individualized assessments."* The account shifted from the burden on officers toward the allocation of general case-management resources. VA's Mail Automation Services (VA-24-4763) similarly described large volumes of claims material in both years, but its 2025 benefits field stated that *"cost savings and increased efficiency data is available upon request."* These examples show that resource pressures and claimed efficiencies remained prominent in agencies' narratives–just informally, in prose, even as the 2025 inventory dropped the dedicated 2024's structured questions on developer-tool waits, infrastructure provisioning and related communications, and computing-resource requests.

4.1.3 Administration and Training: Concentrated Gaps under Continuing Requirements. Conditional requirements substantially narrowed the population in which a missing answer could be interpreted as a longitudinal disclosure loss. For example, of the 1,332 linked records, 26 were required to answer the impact-assessment question in both years, three moved from required to not required, 80 moved in the opposite direction, and 1,066 were not required in either year[5]. Restricting comparisons to continuing requirements identified a more specific pattern of missing governance accounts.

Impact assessment, independent review, ongoing monitoring, and appeal/contestation each had 26 required observations in both 2024 and 2025. Each field lost nine previously available answers (34.6% of its denominator). All these losses involved the same nine VA systems. No gains occurred for impact assessment or independent review, and one each for monitoring and appeal/contestation. As Table 1 shows, nine appeal-related pairs involved other explicit response states rather than a simple answered/blank transition. We want to highlight that the appeal questions changed from a

[5]157 could not be assigned to these binary combinations

Table 1. Response transitions among linked cases required to answer in both 2024 and 2025. Gains are blank-to-answered transitions; losses are answered-to-blank transitions. Explicit *No* counts as an answer. "Other" preserves transitions involving explicit states such as *Unknown*, *Not applicable*, or *Withheld*, rather than combining them with blanks. Each row sums to its own denominator.

Field	*n*	Gain	Loss	Answered both	Blank both	Other
Procurement/development*	548	116	5	425	2	0
Personally Identifiable Information (PII) use	485	102	90	289	3	1
Data description*	548	140	46	294	8	60
Custom-code status	485	110	3	372	0	0
Authorization to Operate	548	110	89	349	0	0
ATO system name	231	0	19	212	0	0
Impact assessment*	26	0	9	17	0	0
Independent review*	26	0	9	17	0	0
Ongoing monitoring*	26	1	9	16	0	0
Appeal/contestation*	26	1	9	7	0	9

*Question scope, response options, or eligibility changed; the comparison does not assume identical constructs. No invalid responses occur in these required-in-both rows. The vendor/contract comparison is excluded because the questions request different identifiers. The source-code-link field has no required-in-both observations because it became optional in 2025.

broader fallback-and-escalation construct to a narrower appeal-process question and replaced the binary Yes/No with five options, including *Not Applicable*, *In-progress*, and *Appeal Precluded by Law*, so these counts reflect response availability under the respective questions.

Across the four governance fields for 227 deployed high-impact use cases in 2025, 406 of 908 field–case observations were blank (44.7%). VA accounted for 376 of these blanks (92.6%): all four fields were blank for each of its 94 eligible records. Thus, the longitudinal losses come from a strongly agency-concentrated reporting gap. The newly introduced operator-training field also separated administrative claims from evidence about professional practice. Among the same 227 use case records, 41 reported established training (18.1%), 81 reported training in progress (35.7%), and 102 were blank (44.9%). Our GPT-based agent also identified three additional responses that answered the training question by describing monitoring and classified them as invalid.

4.2 Algorithmic Decision-Making

The longitudinal records distinguished the availability of an answer from its specificity. Added descriptions varied in detail, similar outputs accompanied different classifications, and accounts of limitations changed alongside the descriptions of how they were handled.

4.2.1 Relevant Data: More Answers Did Not Necessarily Mean More Specific Accounts. Among the 548 pairs required to provide a data description in both years, 140 gained a response (25.5%) and 46 lost one (8.4%). Another 294 remained answered, eight remained blank, and 60 involved other explicit-state transitions (Table 1). Overall, answer gains outweighed losses, but the underlying question broadened: the 2024 field asked about agency-owned data used for training, fine-tuning, or evaluation, whereas the 2025 field covered data more broadly. For the more directly comparable PII-use concept, gains and losses were closer: 102 of 485 pairs gained an answer (21.0%), 90 lost one (18.6%), 289 remained answered, three remained blank, and one involved another explicit state. These changes reflect statements about the data, not measured changes in data collection or PII use.

SmartLINK (DHS-407) illustrates elaboration under the broader prompt. Its 2024 response began with *"N/A"* and explained that the agency did not own the data used to train, fine-tune, or evaluate

the models. In 2025, the data field described *"datasets from diverse facial images and real-world environments"*, along with preprocessing for lighting and facial expressions and augmentation through rotation and scaling. The latter account provided information about data preparation that the earlier field did not mention, but the comparison does not establish that the system newly acquired those data or practices. Accurint offered a contrasting form of added information. Its blank 2024 data field became: *"The case owner relied on DOJ AI governance practices to select and prepare data, as well as evaluate performance."* The response made a procedural assurance available without identifying particular datasets, their composition, or evaluation results in that field. Its purpose narrative continued to mention public and proprietary records, so the entry was not wholly silent about inputs. These differing example cases show that a populated data field can add materially different kinds of information: an account of preparation, a statement about institutional procedure, or a reference that must be interpreted alongside other fields. The numerical increase in answers does not resolve those differences in specificity.

4.2.2 Types of Decision-Support: Similar Outputs across Different Classifications. The paired cases represented systems that scored, classified, retrieved, summarized, or advanced work through administrative processes. Descriptions of those functions did not, by themselves, explain a use case's movement across the high-impact boundary. Accurint, for example, retained its description of generating overviews, noting aliases, and highlighting patterns while moving outside the high-impact category. Its continued account of directing attention toward leads locates an algorithmic role before a final decision, but the inventory does not quantify how that prioritization influences subsequent investigation.

The VA ultrasound entries provide a particularly concise contrast. Vivid iq (VA-24-3213) and Vivid E80/E90/E95 (VA-24-3254) were both classified as rights- and safety-impacting in 2024. In 2025, both gave the output description *"Measurements of areas of interest."* and the same stated benefit of improving ultrasound workflows. Nevertheless, Vivid iq was high-impact, while Vivid E80/E90/E95 was simply described as "not-high-impact" and supplied no classification justification. Their problem descriptions identified different devices and applications, so the records do not establish operational equivalence. They do show that identical, brief accounts of an output and benefit were insufficient to explain the different classificatory destinations.

Conversely, a stated boundary around final decision-making coexisted with high-impact classification. VA's Automated Decision Support (ADS; VA-24-4722) remained within the consequential-use categories across both years. Its 2024 account described extracting information, producing summary documents, requesting examinations, and marking claims ready for decision. The 2025 account expanded the description of documents and workflow actions, while explicitly stating: *"No final benefits decisions are made by ADS, and no payments are initiated by ADS."* The case separates assistance with evidence and workflow from final decisional authority without implying that the former is inconsequential. Across these contrasts, neither an assistive role nor the absence of automated final decisions was sufficient, in the public description alone, to account for classification.

4.2.3 Degree of Uncertainty: Changing Accounts of Limitations and Responses. Descriptions of uncertainty changed in both directions. DOJ's Federal Bureau of Prisons Google Translate entry (DOJ-0153) described word-for-word translation in 2024. Its 2025 output account retained that description but added that *"it does not always accurately translate in a given context."* The use moved from rights-impacting to "presumed high-impact but determined not high-impact", despite a more explicit statement of a limitation. The change makes contextual inaccuracy more visible in the inventory, but it does not establish worsened performance or explain how human personnel identify and correct an inaccurate translation.

SmartLINK more explicitly connected a possible failure to a response. Its 2025 determination justification listed *"poor lighting, camera/phone malfunction"*, described manual comparison of the check-in photograph with earlier photographs, and stated: *"If that fails, the user can schedule an in-person check-in at their local ERO office."* However, environmental limitations and human review were already described in the 2024 risk field. That earlier account cited poor lighting and busy backgrounds and stated that a human examiner reviewed non-matches and considered another attempt. That justification placed an existing account of review, along with an in-person alternative, within an explicit argument that the AI output was not the primary basis for a consequential decision. It does not imply that human review ended in 2025 or that the in-person alternative is automatically an appeal mechanism.

CBP Translate (DHS-2388), classified as rights-impacting in 2024 and high-impact in 2025, illustrates a different redistribution of detail. Its 2024 output field distinguished routine interpretation from sworn statements and official law-enforcement communications, which it said were routed to standard translation services when necessary for formal documentation and questioning. The corresponding 2025 problem, benefits, and output fields no longer stated that distinction. Instead, they described immediate interpretation when human translators were unavailable and specified translated text or audio, retained interactions, and limits on photographing travel documents. The later risk field mentioned inaccurate translation and delays when phone-based services were needed in areas with limited reception. Thus, one previously explicit referral boundary was no longer stated in the same narrative bundle, while other limitations became visible elsewhere.

4.3 Human Discretion

Accounts of professional roles, priorities, and intervention appeared on both sides of the 2025 high-impact boundary. We distinguish a statement of human involvement from an account of the expertise, authority, or reasoning through which it matters.

4.3.1 Professional Expertise: More Explicit Roles and Authority within the Inventory. Several paired cases made human authority more legible inside the inventory itself. In 2024, the output fields for VA's CellaVision DM1200 with the body fluid application (VA-24-5427) and RayStation 11B (VA-24-4443) directed readers to FDA documentation. Their 2025 fields instead described the interaction in the entry. CellaVision stated: *"The operator verifies the classification and has the opportunity to change the suggested classification of any cell."* RayStation described a proposed treatment plan being *"reviewed and approved by authorized intended users"* before treatment administration. Both moved from rights- and safety-impacting classifications to high-impact. These changes identify verification, modification, and approval as distinct forms of authority, instead of monolithically describing human involvement as a single property. The comparison establishes greater specificity within the released inventory. Their narrative descriptions of authority and their blank training-status responses offered different but coexisting views of the organizational conditions for oversight.

ADS made a different aspect of expertise explicit. Alongside the expanded description of its outputs, the 2025 problem field stated that *"ADS is not intended to replace trained claims processors"*. Its summary also referred to page numbers and hyperlinks to original source documents, indicating a reported route from the summary back to the underlying material. Compared to the earlier emphasis on extraction and workflow actions, the later narrative more clearly located those outputs in relation to a named professional role. Such cases add documentation of role, authority, and supporting evidence, without establishing how effectively those arrangements operated.

4.3.2 Value Judgments: Continuity in Priorities and Elaboration of Benefits. The paired records articulated values through both the outcomes agencies sought and the criteria by which they prioritized work. Social Security's Quick Disability Determinations Model retained a purpose

statement identifying cases *"where a favorable disability determination is highly likely and medical evidence is readily available"*. The 2025 output field likewise retained the account of probability scores for allowance and processing time. Its new, separate benefits field additionally claimed that the model *"improves access to benefits for those in urgent need"*, alongside reducing processing time and allocating resources efficiently. The continuing selection criteria and the elaborated benefit claim are related but different: the former identifies which cases the system is intended to prioritize, while the latter explains why that prioritization is presented as valuable. The same use case's 2025 impact narrative listed false negatives and rights- and resource-related impacts among its negative consequences. Thus, it underscored a trade-off – combining a claim about expedited access with acknowledgment that classification and allocation could produce adverse effects. Similarly, Hurricane Score's 2025 account combined consistency and efficiency with individualized assessment, while retaining the 2024 framing of the score as one of several inputs. These examples make multiple institutional objectives visible, but do not explain how those considerations are weighed or resolved.

Changes in the questions also affected where those values surfaced. However, we differentiated between relocating existing value language and adding new explanation. SmartLINK's 2024 combined purpose-and-benefits text, describing reduced intrusiveness relative to a GPS unit and fewer routine in-person check-ins, carried into the 2025 benefits field with little change. In contrast, the Quick Disability Determinations entry elaborated benefits while retaining its purpose.

4.3.3 Heuristic Decision-Making: Specified Intervention Points, Less Specified Reasoning. Accounts of human review did not align neatly with classification outcomes. SmartLINK repeated the same sentence in both years: *"In either scenario, a human can evaluate the response."* This statement preceded the change from rights-impacting to "presumed high-impact but determined not high-impact". As the earlier risk and appeal-related explanations also specified human review, the classification change cannot be attributed simply to the first appearance of a human-involvement claim. In 2025, the new justification connected that involvement and an alternative check-in route to the asserted limit on the output's decisional role.

Axon's Video Retention Solution for object recognition and redaction (DOJ-0225) provides a contrasting trajectory. Its 2024 output was described only as a recommendation. The 2025 account specified a draft video with selected redactions and stated that the file was not complete until human intervention *"validates and/or corrects AI suggestions."* The use moved from rights-impacting to high-impact, while its operator-training response reported training in progress. Here, human correction was represented as part of the workflow without serving, in that record, as a sufficient reason for a not-high-impact classification. The contrast between SmartLINK and Axon concerns how review was situated in two different accounts. However, it does not establish that the systems or their consequences were otherwise comparable.

Hurricane Score more directly connected an output to contextual judgment. Its 2024 account already described the risk score as one of many factors officers used. In 2025, the output narrative added information about inputs, model type, and periodic case review, while explaining: *"Officers may then consider this score, along with many other factors, when determining whether current levels of case management or technology assignment remain appropriate or should be adjusted."* This specifies a point of judgment and possible actions, but does not explain which other factors take precedence, how conflicting evidence is resolved, or when an officer should discount the score. Likewise, a right to correct a cell classification or redaction identifies an intervention without revealing the cognitive strategy used to make it. Overall, these accounts deserve credit for describing opportunities and authority for judgment more concretely than vaguely referring to situated heuristics.

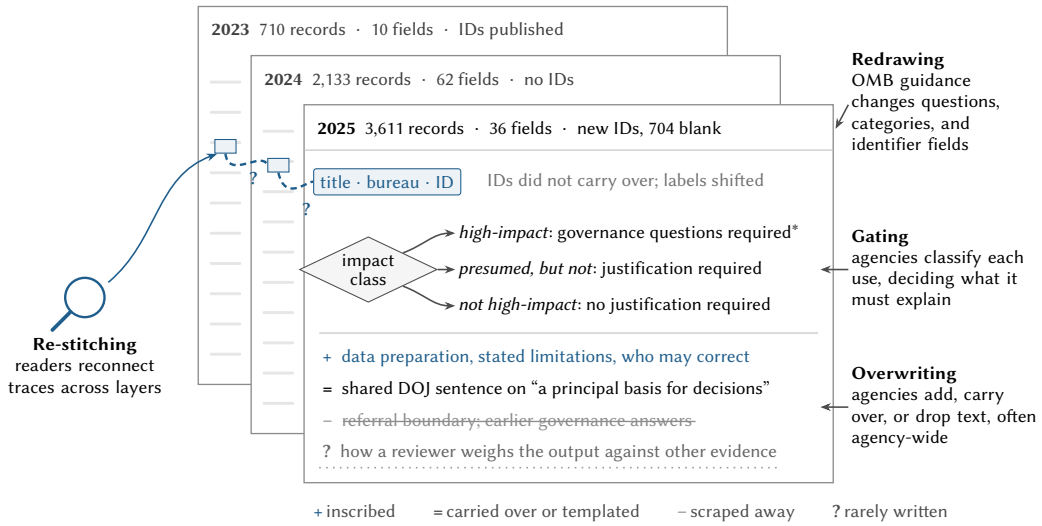


Fig. 1. The inventory as a palimpsest, where each annual release is written over the previous one.

5 Discussion

Our results suggest that a longer list of use cases did not necessarily make federal AI easier to follow. First, identifiers did not carry over: none of the systems we matched across 2023 and 2025 with a stable identifier at both points. Second, about one in six matched systems that agencies had previously classified as affecting people's rights or safety fell outside the new *high-impact* category. Among such deployed systems in both years, half explained this shift by a single boilerplate sentence repeated across entries, while the rest were not explained at all. Third, where comparable governance questions applied in both years, every answer that disappeared came from the same nine systems in one federal department. Finally, some entries became more specific about data preparation, limitations, and who could correct an output, but rarely explained how people weighed an output against other evidence. In other words, successive releases provided more visibility into the range of federal AI uses while offering limited visibility into how any particular use was reclassified, rephrased, or overseen.

We describe the process behind these patterns through the metaphor of a palimpsest–a manuscript page scraped and written over, on which traces of the earlier writing remain partly legible [29]. Each annual inventory is written over the previous one: its questions and categories are redrawn, and agencies rewrite their entries, so that some earlier inscriptions survive while others disappear. Following Dillon's use of "palimpsestic" for this process of layering [28], we propose the term *"palimpsestic accountability."* It means that the accountability an inventory supports depends not only on what each release discloses, but also on whether the layers of successive accounts can still be identified, separated, and connected. This is not a claim that agencies concealed information or that safeguards disappeared, but a description of how routine changes in reporting practices shift accountability interoperability from the institutions that produce a record to the people who read it. Figure 1 shows four mechanisms through which this shift occurred across bureaucratic processes, algorithmic decision-making, and human discretion.

First, *redrawing* changed the page itself. The public files grew from 10 to 62 fields and then shrank to 36, and the 2025 release added training, fail-safe, and justification fields while dropping questions about infrastructure support, human involvement, notice, disparity mitigation, and opting out.

Without a record of these changes, readers cannot tell whether an agency's practice changed or only the questions that were asked. The page also changed between releases. OMB guidance encourages agencies to update their public inventories on an ongoing basis [75], and DHS's July 2026 update retired four uses, including Hurricane Score, one of the systems we followed [110].

Second, *gating* tied bureaucratic rules to accounts of algorithmic decision-making. In 2025, governance questions were required only for deployed *high-impact* uses, and a justification only for use cases that were classified *presumed high-impact but determined not high-impact* [75, 76]. Though classifications shape what becomes visible and actionable within institutions [13], in the inventory, the determination that decides what must be explained is itself among the least explained. In the previous section, we discussed example use cases where required explanations were missing, moved to a different category without the required justification, or erased from completed risk-management sections. Such downgrades underscore policy counsels' frustration that "the determination that requires the most explanation is the one that comes with the least" [110].

Third, *overwriting* across agencies both added and removed information. For example, while our analysis based on submissions due in December 2025 found that VA left all four governance fields blank for 94 deployed *high-impact* use cases, after the April 2026 deadline for reporting risk-management practices, VA had completed these fields for 90 uses and moved four others to pre-deployment or retirement [109]. This highlights why the blanks should not be read as evidence that safeguards were absent. Instead, they emphasize how the consolidated record made it difficult to distinguish a pending update from an unanswered question. Similarly, accounts of human discretion were overwritten. We showed two examples in the previous section, where statements that a person reviews or can correct an output appeared on both sides of the *high-impact* boundary. Such statements also circulate as general assurances. For example, while DHS's description of Hurricane Score was that the score was used "to inform human decision-making" [81], those accounts were criticized for raising "more questions than it answers" and that system was later retired [110]. A major concern about using human discretion as a compensatory mechanism is that oversight policies often presume capacities that reviewers lack [40]. Moreover, we found that fewer than one in five deployed *high-impact* uses in 2025 reported established operator training. Thus, documented human involvement in the inventory is usually a role and rarely the conditions under which judgment could be exercised.

Finally, *re-stitching* was left to the public. We had to reconstruct continuity from titles, bureaus, and descriptions and manually review fuzzy-matched candidate pairs. While traceability is often described as a principle for operationalizing accountability [56], readers had to rebuild traceability across the US AI use case inventories.

These mechanisms suggest four recommendations. First, OMB and agencies should preserve the history of the inventories and each use through persistent public identifiers, explicit links for renamed or reorganized entries, a change log of added, removed, or reworded questions and categories, and dated updates reconciled with the consolidated inventory. Second, explanation requirements should follow the classification boundary. Whenever a use previously classified as rights-impacting, safety-impacting, or *high-impact* and vice versa is classified otherwise, its entry should state the previous and new categories, the responsible office, the evidence considered, and whether the system, the criteria, or the record changed. Third, public files should keep overwriting visible by distinguishing a blank required answer from a pending update, an ended requirement, a withheld answer, and an explicit *not applicable*, and by carrying forward stated limitations until those systems are retired. Fourth, federal agencies should document human oversight as a set of conditions, including when review occurs, what evidence reviewers receive, whether they can reject an output, and what training and time they have. Entries should also tell affected people how to contest an outcome, since a fallback is not necessarily the same as an appeal.

6 Conclusion

In this paper, we traced the US Federal AI Use Case Inventory across three annual releases, reading it as a record written over successive reporting cycles rather than as independent snapshots. We showed that re-classifications were rarely explained in case-specific terms and accounts of human oversight described roles more often than the conditions for judgment. While our paper relies on mixed methods analyses of US Federal agencies' accounts, future work using ethnography and interviews with oversight staff, frontline workers, and affected communities could connect these accounts to how systems are used and contested and explain why uses were reclassified or safeguards changed, which public entries alone cannot establish. For FAccT researchers, this means moving beyond evaluating what a single release discloses toward examining how successive releases redraw, reclassify, and overwrite the accounts they carry forward.

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A Appendix

A.1 Supplementary Methods: Linkage and Response Classification

A.1.1 Record Linkage.

Normalization and deterministic matching. We blocked comparisons by canonical agency code, including the alias from DOS to STATE. For comparison strings, we collapsed whitespace, lowercased text, and retained only ASCII letters and digits, while keeping the original values. Title normalization also removed standalone occurrences of "AI" and "artificial intelligence." We removed inventory annotations and leading "Renamed:" markers, and retained both the full title and the names on either side of a "Previously:" marker as aliases. Identifier and bureau-key normalization additionally replaced ampersands with "and" and removed the words "the," "of," "for," "a," and "an."

Among unmatched records, deterministic matching first identified unique agency–identifier matches and then unique agency–title-alias matches. Repeated exact titles could be disambiguated by equivalent bureau labels: labels equal after normalization, one label (of at least three characters) contained in the other, or one label's token set contained in the other's. These matches had to be unique in both directions. The final deterministic step identified pairs in which one normalized title alias began with the other, the shorter alias contained at least 40 characters, and the pair was unique in both directions. No accepted link in these releases originated from the identifier step (Table 2).

Similarity scores. For unmatched records, title and bureau scores combined character-sequence similarity (R), token-set Jaccard overlap (J), and token containment (C):

$$S_{\text{title/bureau}} = 0.45R + 0.35J + 0.20C. \quad (1)$$

Character similarity used Python's `difflib.SequenceMatcher`. Jaccard overlap divided the number of shared tokens by the size of their union, and containment divided the shared-token count by the size of the smaller token set. Title comparison used the highest-scoring pair of aliases, and bureau similarity used the same scoring function.

Description comparison used the 2023 summary, the combined 2024 purpose-and-benefits and output fields, and the combined 2025 problem, benefits, and output fields. We compared their normalized token sets using $S_{\text{description}} = 0.60J + 0.40C$. The composite score was

$$S = 0.72S_{\text{title}} + 0.20S_{\text{description}} + 0.08S_{\text{bureau}}. \quad (2)$$

Empty comparisons contributed zero without redistributing weights. An exact normalized title-alias match raised the composite score to at least 0.98, and an exact nonempty normalized identifier match set it to 1.00. These scores were candidate-generation heuristics rather than calibrated match probabilities.

Assignment and review. Maximum-weight Hungarian assignment produced one-to-one candidates within each agency. After assignment, a pair advanced to author review if $S \geq 0.48$ and either $S_{\text{title}} \geq 0.50$, or both $S_{\text{title}} \geq 0.35$ and $S_{\text{description}} \geq 0.45$. Review margins recorded the selected score minus the strongest competing score for each endpoint. Only accepted candidates entered the panels alongside deterministic matches. Table 2 reports the matches by method and the review decisions by panel.

Table 2. Deterministic matches by method, candidate-review decisions, and accepted links. The three panels were constructed separately. No deterministic match came from an identifier.

	Deterministic			Candidate review				
Panel	Title	Title + bureau	Title prefix	Reviewed	Accepted	Rejected	Uncertain	Total links
2023–2024	210	0	2	44	42	1	1	254
2024–2025	1,126	18	18	186	170	16	0	1,332
2023–2025	187	0	2	43	38	5	0	227

A.1.2 Response Classification. The response classifier normalized whitespace, case, and typographic dashes before applying field-specific overrides and configured response tokens. Empty values and the literal placeholders `[]`, `{}`, `null`, and `nan` were classified as Blank. Not-applicable tokens included `na`, `n/a`, `n.a.`, `not applicable`, and `not-applicable`. Unknown tokens included "unknown," "undetermined," "to be determined," "tbd," "not available," and the exact answer `Unknown, see "Comments" field`. Withheld tokens covered standalone withholding and redaction notices, such as "withheld," "not publicly releasable," "REDACTED," and "Redacted for cybersecurity purposes."

No included the configured negative tokens ("no," "false," "none," and "none of the above") and normalized responses beginning with "no " or "no -". The Invalid overrides matched documented wrong-question responses by year, field, and normalized text: two distinct monitoring answers (three responses) in the 2025 operator-training field and one independent-review answer in the 2025 monitoring field. Other non-blank responses were classified as Present. Thus, a response beginning with "N/A" and continuing with an explanation was not automatically assigned Not

applicable; unless it matched another configured rule, it remained Present. The classifier did not semantically evaluate every response. The configuration files retain the exact matching rules and documented overrides.